UNIVERSITY OF THE PEOPLE

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Unit 4 Assignment

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Critical Appreciation of "The Negro Speaks of Rivers" by Langston Hughes

Langston Hughes's "The Negro Speaks of Rivers" is a powerful example of modernist lyric poetry that connects individual identity with African American history and the long memory of human civilization. Included in *Compact Anthology of World Literature, Part Six*, the poem belongs to the Modernism section and demonstrates Hughes's ability to combine a simple poetic structure with profound historical and cultural meaning (Turlington et al., 2022). Through free verse, repetition, imagery, symbolism, and carefully chosen geographical references, Hughes presents the river as a central metaphor for ancestry, continuity, and collective identity.

The poem can be classified as free verse because it does not follow a fixed rhyme scheme or regular metrical pattern. Instead, Hughes creates structure through repetition, line arrangement, parallel phrasing, and a flowing rhythm. The repeated statement "I've known rivers" establishes a strong structural frame, while the recurring idea that the speaker's soul has "grown deep" like rivers connects the beginning and ending of the poem (Hughes, 1921/2002). This repetition gives the poem a musical quality without requiring a conventional rhyme scheme. The rhythm is particularly important because Hughes's poetry was influenced by African American musical traditions, including spirituals and blues (Poetry Foundation, n.d.).

A close reading of the poem shows that the rivers are much more than geographical locations. Hughes names the Euphrates, Congo, Nile, and Mississippi, creating a historical journey across Africa, Asia, and North America. The Euphrates evokes ancient civilization, while the Congo connects the speaker with Africa and ancestral origins. The Nile is associated with the construction of the pyramids, linking the speaker to one of the world's ancient civilizations. Finally, the Mississippi connects the poem to African American history in the United States, particularly through the reference to Abraham Lincoln (Turlington et al., 2022). The sequence therefore expands the speaker's identity beyond a single place or historical period.

Hughes also uses vivid personification and sensory imagery. The Congo "lulled" the speaker to sleep, while the Mississippi is described through its "singing" and its changing appearance in the sunset. These choices make the rivers seem alive and capable of carrying memory across generations. The contrast between the "muddy" Mississippi and its golden appearance also demonstrates how Hughes transforms an ordinary physical landscape into a symbolic representation of historical experience. Scholarly criticism similarly identifies the rivers as central to Hughes's meditation on African American heritage and ancestry (Dworkin, 2017).

The poem's most significant rhetorical element is its extended symbolism of rivers. Rivers continuously move while connecting different places and generations. Hughes uses this quality to suggest that African American identity is not limited to the history of oppression in the United States but is connected to much older civilizations and experiences. The phrase "My soul has grown deep like the rivers" therefore functions as more than a comparison; it expresses historical depth, resilience, and belonging (Hughes, 1921/2002). The poem's repetition and flowing rhythm reinforce this sense of continuity.

Overall, "The Negro Speaks of Rivers" demonstrates how a relatively short free-verse poem can contain considerable historical and emotional depth. Hughes combines structure, rhythm, repetition, imagery, personification, and symbolism to transform rivers into carriers of memory. His close connection between the speaker's soul and ancient rivers ultimately presents identity as something shaped by collective history rather than by one moment or location. The poem is therefore both a personal meditation and a broader reflection on ancestry, cultural memory, and human continuity.

References

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